The French education system

Hi everyone, and welcome! This is episode fifteen of the Cottongue Podcast!

[00:00:13] Welcome. I'm very happy to welcome you to this new podcast. As usual, I hope you're well and feeling fit. I hope you're having a good holiday if you're on holiday, or that your working week isn't too hard.

[00:00:36] To begin, I wanted to tell you about a very nice message I received on the Cottongue fan page. You know I created a Facebook fan page to share videos, information and interesting things with you. Of course, you can also contact me and send messages there. That's what Michael decided to do. Michael is Canadian and lives in Ontario, and I'd like to read his message. Listen to the message I received from Michael.

[00:01:34] "Hey! I wanted to send you a message to say thank you. Your podcast helped me return to French. I'm from Ontario, Canada, in a mainly English-speaking area. I did primary and secondary school in French, but for almost ten years I've been using it less and less. I don't want to lose it, and your podcast helps. I like the concept of ignoring grammar and simply discussing something interesting. I completely agree there's plenty of material for beginners and advanced learners, but not for intermediate learners.

Thanks again.

I'd like you to talk more about the media in France if possible. Michael"

[00:02:43] Thank you, Michael, for this message. Of course, I answered, because I reply to every message I receive. You see, Michael agrees grammar is good, but doing something a little different may be more interesting. You know that's this podcast's goal: offering interesting things to listen to in French, to acquire the language more naturally. I discussed this a lot in the first podcast, so if you haven't listened to it, you can after this one.

[00:03:35] I'm very happy to help my Canadian friends. I really like Canada and the French spoken in Quebec. I find it a very lovely way of speaking French. They use some different expressions, and their pronunciation and accent also differ. Some French people find it funny, but personally I find it lovely, beautiful, and love watching films in Quebec French. Perhaps you know director Xavier Dolan, from Montreal. I love his films and recommend watching them if you never have. That way, you can hear Quebec French and learn very nice expressions!

[00:04:48] "Niaise pas!" There's the famous expression "Niaise pas avec la puck", from hockey, with the puck, the disc. So "niaise pas" means "get straight to the point".

[00:04:58] Today, we'll talk about the French education system. But I won't give a detailed description of different schools, because that could be a little boring. Instead, I'll discuss my personal experience. This will let you form an idea, imagine what a pupil's life is like in the French system. Knowing a country's education system is very important, I think, because through it, values and ways of thinking are passed to new generations. To know a country and its culture well, knowing what people study at school matters. I'll discuss aspects I personally find positive, but also more negative things: the system's advantages and disadvantages.

[00:06:28] OK, are you ready to relive my school years with me? Come on, here we go, back to school!

[00:06:45] I come from a small town in central France called Châteauroux. It has about fifty thousand inhabitants and nothing really special, nothing particular about it. I'd say it's a small town like many others in France.

[00:07:12] When I was three, I began nursery school. Nursery school is for children aged three to six, so it lasts three years. It isn't compulsory, it's optional, but generally the great majority of children attend. More than 90% go to nursery school. What did I learn there? I learned to live in a community different from my family. Nursery school is very important for children to learn to socialise, live with others. It's where we make our first friends, and perhaps our first enemies too.

[00:08:19] I have rather good memories of nursery school. I think I was quite happy to go, made lots of friends, and then at six entered primary school.

[00:08:37] Primary school, also called elementary school, lasts five years. We're six when we arrive and eleven when we finish. There, we begin learning serious things: reading, writing and counting. We're introduced to science and history, and begin doing more concrete, more serious things. I loved primary school because learning to read made me very happy. That mattered a lot, because I later became an avid reader. An avid reader, as you understand, is someone who loves reading. As a child, I loved reading books in the evening before falling asleep, and primary school taught me to read.

[00:09:57] Afterwards, I went to collège. Be careful: in French, collège is the school children attend between eleven and fifteen. I know "college" means something different in the United States: university. In France, collège is completely different, the school before lycée, upper secondary school. French children therefore go to collège at eleven. This doesn't mean they're more intelligent than Americans. The word simply designates something different in French and English.

[00:10:48] My collège was in a difficult neighbourhood, a suburban neighbourhood. In France, "banlieue" means neighbourhoods generally outside cities, on their outskirts, where families with less money, more modest families, live. There, I began seeing society differently. I met people from quite different backgrounds and became aware of inequalities. For example, some friends shared a bedroom with two or three brothers, while I was lucky enough to have my own room at my parents' house. I saw we didn't all have the same opportunities or living conditions. I also understood these conditions greatly influence success at school. Naturally, concentrating and doing homework alone in my room with my little desk was easier than for friends sharing with three brothers. Competition also begins at collège. Pupils receive marks from zero to twenty. In the United States and England, I believe, pupils receive letters: A, B, C, C minus, C plus and so on. In France, marks run from zero to twenty. Zero is the worst, twenty the maximum. To reach the pass mark, to pass an exam, you need ten, ten out of twenty.

[00:13:30] There are four years at collège, as I said. The first is called sixième, then cinquième, quatrième and troisième. At the end of troisième, there's a first fairly important examination called the brevet. To finish collège, you must obtain the brevet.

[00:14:01] After collège, selection between pupils begins. Not everyone has the same possibilities. Depending on the marks obtained, different options are available. Pupils with

the worst results generally have to follow a vocational track: very short studies lasting two years, teaching a trade, generally a technical profession. In France, school is compulsory until sixteen, so afterwards pupils with a vocational qualification can stop studying and begin working. These trades are very important but unfortunately have a rather negative image. Learning them is seen as punishment for insufficiently good results at collège. Pupils are sometimes a little ashamed of vocational studies and find staying motivated and focused quite difficult.

[00:15:50] Other pupils, those with good results at collège and in the brevet examination, can go to lycée. You enter at fifteen and finish at eighteen. If you're good at arithmetic, you've understood it lasts three years. There are different types: general, technological and vocational lycées. We've discussed vocational education a little. General lycée is for pupils with good marks. The first class is called seconde. You arrive in seconde, then première and terminale.

[00:16:57] I went to a good lycée in the centre of my town. Its pupils were quite different from those I'd known at collège. Once again, this let me discover people from other backgrounds, and I had to adapt to this new environment.

[00:17:25] After seconde, there's a choice of three programmes: science, emphasising mathematics, physics and biology; economic and social studies, focusing on economics and the human sciences; and finally literature, for literature and foreign languages, of course.

[00:18:04] I chose economic and social studies because these subjects interested me a lot and I wanted to know more. I also really liked lycée because this is when schools try to develop pupils' critical thinking. In France, arguing a case and presenting ideas in an organised way is very important. At lycée, we learn, for example, to write essays. In philosophy classes, for example, there's a topic, generally a question, that we must answer in several parts. Structure is very important. There must always be arguments for and against, the view supporting a theory and the view opposing it. Schools insist pupils learn to think with nuance. There isn't simply good and evil, right and wrong, but a complex reality we must analyse to understand better. These are skills and ideas passed on at lycée. Personally, I consider this critical thinking a great advantage of the French education system.

[00:20:01] At the end of the last year of lycée, pupils take their most important examination, the baccalauréat. Because the word is a little long, we say "bac". At the end of terminale, pupils take the bac and must pass to continue into higher education. Be careful: French is a little different here. "Passer un examen" means taking an exam, but afterwards you can pass or fail it. So "j'ai passé un examen" means you attempted an exam, not that you passed it. Pay attention to this little difference, because it isn't like English, for example.

[00:21:11] After passing the bac, pupils can begin higher education. They can go to university, and most decide to do so, to study different things, perhaps literature, law or medicine. They can obtain a three-year degree called the licence, or a five-year qualification called the master's. If they want research or teaching, meaning becoming a university professor, they can do a doctorate. But they need great motivation, because that takes eight years. Obtaining a doctorate requires eight years of study.

[00:22:09] Personally, I chose something a little different: prépa. Prépa, also called classe préparatoire, is specifically French and exists only in France. Preparatory classes are in lycées, and for two years you prepare competitive entrance examinations for grandes écoles. These are France's most prestigious schools, for example engineering, business or political

science schools. Perhaps you've heard of Polytechnique, an engineering school, or HEC, a business school. In France, these are called grandes écoles, and they're generally the most selective and difficult courses to enter.

[00:23:14] To enter these grandes écoles, you must prepare for an examination in preparatory classes. For me, these were two very interesting but intense years. There are about thirty hours of classes weekly, but also two oral exams each week and a four-hour written exam every Friday or Saturday. Prépa therefore has a reputation for being very difficult, and studying so intensely for two years requires real motivation.

[00:24:07] After these two years, you take competitive entrance examinations for grandes écoles. Of course, there isn't room for everyone, so the best students enter the best schools. This system is heavily criticised in France because it promotes inequality. Since admission is very difficult, generally the great majority of students come from quite well-off families, meaning families with a fair amount of money. These families know attending grandes écoles matters for obtaining a good qualification and then a good job.

[00:25:11] These schools are also private and quite expensive. If parents can't pay, students must request a bank loan to finance their studies. Paying for a grande école isn't easy for everyone.

[00:25:37] In reality, only 5% of students attend these schools, so very few. After prépa, I entered a business school in Paris and studied there for three years to obtain a master's degree.

[00:26:03] That's how I finished my studies, my education in France, with a master's.

[00:26:18] In conclusion, the French education system passes on good values, such as the critical thinking I discussed, but unfortunately is very unequal. Studies often compare education systems worldwide. The most famous is called PISA, and in its latest study, France is considered the most unequal country for education. This means pupils from more modest families find succeeding at school in France quite difficult and ultimately have less chance of obtaining a good qualification.

[00:27:14] One final point about language: be careful, because saying someone is "bien éduqué" in French means they received a good upbringing from their parents, not from school! It means they're polite and well-mannered. To say someone studied well, we can say they have a good qualification. We don't say "il est bien éduqué", but "il a un bon diplôme", he has a good qualification, or "il a fait de bonnes études", he has completed good studies.

[00:27:55] Now you know more about the French education system. I hope you enjoyed reliving my school years with me. If you have questions, things you didn't understand, or want me to discuss a subject in more detail, don't hesitate to write on Facebook or email hugo@innerfrench.com.

[00:28:37] That's all for today. As usual, I invite you to look at the transcript on my website if you didn't understand everything. Join me next week for a new podcast. Thank you, everyone, and see you soon!